

Teamwork Skills: Communicating Effectively in Groups

Case Study Creation: A proposal in a crisis

By Javier A. Jaime Serrano

Introduction

It was early Monday morning at the office, the current project was coming to an end. Final packages were being inspected that week just before delivery to the client, the impossible deadlines from months ago were successfully achieved. It has been a difficult month, my Boss the Manager was self-isolating from a trip to China, where the pandemic has started, and a co-worker in the already reduced team had recently resigned.

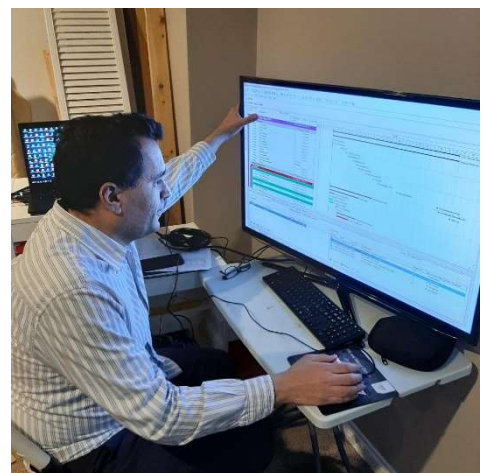
Even with the successful completion of the last packages, the mood in the office was not good. Everybody knew that we needed to get a new Project, or we will have to face a mass lay-off. But It is a full Moon on a Monday a superstitious coworker commented, and I questioned if it is really a sign of good luck when the work-week end in Friday 13th, what can go wrong?

The Proposal

In the same day afternoon the team got called to a meeting, the Director, announced that we just received a request for proposal (RFP) from a client, and that we need it, to “raise the bar” and work even harder to get the new Project awarded. There were a lot of clarifications to be made and not a similar project to use as a template. But it was on the hands of the Engineering and Design departments to produce all the drawings first. These detail drawings were not specifically asked in the RFP, but the Director offered to the client to impress them. For my department, Project Controls, it was an easy doable task if we can get the promised information from Engineering by Friday. The RFP only required a level 2 schedule and a class 4 estimate, this was confirmed by the Director. These high-level Schedule and cost estimate can be calculated top-down from known company standards.

The Pandemic

By Thursday afternoon the pandemic was declared global and new measures were announced. At work we were asked to be prepared, take our laptops home, and install and test all the tools required to work remotely. After the scare on Thursday, it was on Friday 13th that we were told that remote work was mandatory for non-essential office personal like us. So we took everything we needed from our offices, and with a foldable patio table and an old TV screen set up my new home office in my house basement that same Friday afternoon.



The Confusion

On Sunday afternoon I received a text message from the Manager, after completed the self-isolation period, she met the Director and requested a special permission to work in the office just for a day, and only the three of us, the Planner (me), the Estimator and the Manager. We knew it was going to be a long day, the reports from the current project were due next day, and the information required to build the proposal schedule and estimate was not received on Friday as originally promised.

Back in the office on Monday, the Estimator asks me for the duration of each phase of the proposal project, in a quick top down calculation I gave him a rough estimate of these durations. After the first estimate meeting the Manager came to me looking surprised asked to see the Level 3 detailed schedule, what Level 3 schedule? I commented, I will work on the Level 2 proposal schedule after finishing the current Project reports that were due next day.

The Manager explained that in the estimating meeting, the Estimator told the Director that he got the dates needed from the schedule, and it was assumed that the schedule was ready, the Director wanted to see the schedule and called a meeting to review it. Luckily for me, the Monday afternoon was cancelled, and I was able to submit the current project report on time.

Next day, at my new home office with all the information required, and in a virtual meeting with the Manager, I confirmed the schedule requirements, the Director assuming we had a high-level schedule ready, committed to have a detailed level 3 schedule that same week.

The Work

So we get to work, with the schedule review meeting now on Wednesday and with all the new virtual meetings, there was not enough time. By Wednesday, the Engineering portion of the schedule was completed and reviewed with the Manager, major equipment deliveries had to be assumed until formal quotes received. It was not ready but good enough, with the meeting being virtual, I was able to show the portion I considered complete by a partial screen mirror.

The meeting went well, and the Director and his higher ups discussed the strategical implications of the schedule and gave me a few suggestions to reduce the duration a couple of months. But I still need to receive the quoted deliveries dates and do a risk analysis, and that afternoon the server for the scheduling tools went down.

Next day with the servers still down, we continue receiving mark-downs, the Engineering Manager, that was invited but not attended the meeting, gave me instructions contradicting the Director. These must be escalated, and my Boss the Manager called another meeting where I was not required. With all the mark-ups printed and checked and the schedule tool servers still down, there was nothing else to do than wait.

The Submission

After dinner at home, Thursday night, I tried one more time to log into the schedule server and It worked! So I was able to implement the mark ups that night and save the files in the proposal folder for the final review meeting. Friday Monday the schedule tool server was down again, and the Manager commented in the final review meeting that we were not able to incorporate last minutes due to the difficulties from the scheduling tool server. The Estimator told me that he heard that the Client was asking for new requirement and that the submission deadline was moved to the next week, but this was not communicated to the team, so it is to hurry up and wait again. During the second week from home, we started to get use to the new normal, the tools were working, and the team was available for quick video meetings at the usual working hours, the proposal was submitted on time and the project was put on hold with no decision.

Supplemental Materials

Main Characters:

The Director: Director of the Projects division of the Company, and direct supervisor of the Manager on the Team.

The (Project Controls) Manager: Project Controls Department Manager, and direct supervisor of Planner (me), Estimator, and Cost Controller (vacant position).

Planner (me): In charge of the Proposal Plans and maintenance of Schedules, also covering the Cost Controller (Reporting) role.

(Cost) Estimator: In charge of the Cost Estimate for the Proposal, with temporary contract.

Engineering Manager: In charge of the Engineering of the Proposal, and direct supervisor of the Engineering team.

Learning Objectives:

- To show how communication breaks occurs with suddenly changes in the interaction Design of the office environment.
- To show how a simply misunderstanding can evolve to a major problem when not clarified early.
- To show the hidden traps in the decision making done by the Director.
- To show how conflict can develop when not all affected parties attend a key meeting.
- To show the challenge of virtual work when abruptly implemented.

Key Terms:

Request for Proposal (RFP): Document soliciting a proposal, made through a bidding process by a client company interested in procurement of an asset to potential suppliers.

Cost Estimate: The approximation of the cost of a project made by the Estimator with Engineering input. The Class depends on the definition level and a probability percent.

Proposal (Project) Schedule: A living document used to ensure all the work needed to complete a project is done on time. The Level depend on the detailing of the activities.

Interaction Design: The basic architecture if you will, of norms, rules, and expectations, which guide our choices and our interpretation of the choices of other people. In this case as part of the Office environment that once removed caused the communication breaks.

Group Development: Relates to how groups come together and develop, through socialization, norms, and roles. In this case a team was put together for a proposal without knowing our roles, times available or previous socialization.

Decision Making Trap: Common mistakes made by our hidden biases and distortions in our thinking when making decisions. In this case looking to “raise the bar” before evaluating the proposal can be consider Anchoring, and the proposal meeting considered a Framing example.

Conflict Resolution: The process by which two or more parties reach a peaceful resolution to a dispute. In this case the Engineering Manager complains about not implementing his suggested schedule dates was resolved by the Manager negotiation, without further escalation.

Virtual Office Environment: Work environments that are delivered and accessed through Web-based communication and computing technologies. In this case the mandatory remote work for office personal caused a lot of technical difficulties like the crash of a server or network problems.

Discussion Questions:

- What decision-making traps were made by the Director in the RFP announcement?
- Which communication breaks occurred by the suddenly change to an environment without the same Interaction design?
- Could the confusion by the Estimator about the schedule development be avoided by group development?
- Is the misunderstanding of a level 2 schedule requirement by the planner a decision-making trap?
- Could the conflict with the Engineering Manager be avoided if he attended the meeting?